

LEGISLATIVE OVERVIEW

2026 Session Legislative Overview

Bitcoin, blockchain, and digital asset legislation in Rhode Island — status, summaries, and RIBPI positions as of June 6, 2026

Rhode Island Bitcoin Policy Initiative | June 2026

The 2026 Rhode Island legislative session features an unprecedented volume of bills addressing Bitcoin, blockchain, and digital assets. These bills span six policy areas: studying blockchain's potential, encouraging blockchain innovation, enabling decentralized governance structures, protecting citizens' digital property rights, reducing friction for digital asset payments, and regulating virtual currency kiosks. This overview summarizes each bill, its current procedural status, and RIBPI's position. Bill statuses are verified against status.rilegislature.gov as of June 6, 2026.

8 bills 2026 RI bills RIBPI tracks	Jun 10 S.2198 Sub A Senate floor vote (Wed)	Jun 8 S.2021 Senate Finance hearing (Mon)	46th RI on CNBC business climate (2025)
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1. STUDYING BLOCKCHAIN'S POTENTIAL

H.7956 (House) / S.2198 Sub A (Senate) — Blockchain Study Commission

House: Rep. Casey | Innovation, Internet & Technology Committee (heard 3/5/26, held for further study). **Senate:** Sens. DiPalma, Gu, Burke, Urso, Paolino, Zurier | AI & Emerging Technology Committee. **S.2198 Sub A reported out of committee with a do-pass recommendation on June 2, 2026 and is on the Senate Calendar for a floor vote on Wednesday, June 10, 2026.** Predecessor: 2025's H.5810 / S.0373 (S.0373 passed Senate 38–0; no House vote).

S.2198 Sub A creates a 10-member special legislative commission (the originally introduced version had five members) to examine how Rhode Island can benefit from blockchain technology and digital assets. Membership includes legislators, the DBR Director, the Secretary of Commerce, and public members with expertise in academia, finance, and securities law. The commission must deliver an interim report by January 5, 2027 and a final report by January 5, 2028. The commission sunsets February 5, 2028.

RIBPI Position: Strong Support

The Senate already passed an analogous resolution unanimously in 2025; the 2026 effort has now advanced further than at any point. **S.2198 Sub A is recommended for affirmative vote on the Senate floor June 10.** Following Senate passage, House Innovation, Internet & Technology should take up H.7956 before sine die adjournment in late June.

2. ENCOURAGING BLOCKCHAIN INNOVATION

H.7413 — Rhode Island Economic Growth Blockchain Act

Introduced January 30, 2026 by Rep. Place. House Corporations Committee. Heard February 3, 2026; held for further study.

The most ambitious blockchain bill in Rhode Island history. H.7413 would create three institutional structures: (1) a 13-member Rhode Island Blockchain Technology Advisory Council appointed by the Governor and Commerce Corporation; (2) a financial technology regulatory sandbox allowing innovators to test new products with temporary regulatory waivers, administered by the Superintendent of Banking with a 24-month sandbox period; and (3) a new category of Special Purpose Depository Institutions (SPDIs) — state-chartered banks designed specifically to serve digital asset businesses, requiring 100% liquid reserves.

RIBPI Position: Support

H.7413 represents the kind of comprehensive, pro-innovation framework that Wyoming has used to attract digital asset investment. The SPDI charter would make Rhode Island the third state to offer the structure (after Wyoming and Nebraska) and the first in New England. RIBPI's 16-page Fiscal Impact Analysis projects net positive direct fiscal impact by Year 5 under moderate uptake assumptions.

3. ENABLING DECENTRALIZED GOVERNANCE

H.7843 — Rhode Island Decentralized Autonomous Organization Act

Introduced February 27, 2026 by Rep. Stephen M. Casey. House Corporations Committee. Heard April 2, 2026; held for further study.

H.7843 would add a new Chapter 17 to Title 7 of the Rhode Island General Laws, establishing a legal framework for Decentralized Autonomous Organizations (DAOs) to operate as limited liability companies. Rhode Island would become the fifth state to enact a DAO-specific framework after Vermont (2018), Wyoming (2021), Tennessee (2022), and Utah (2023).

RIBPI Position: Support with Amendments

RIBPI supports the intent and direction. The bill contains seven addressable drafting gaps including the absence of statutory definitions, duplicate section numbering (§ 7-17-7 appears twice), undefined relationship to the existing LLC statute, vague sandbox parameters, no

implementation runway, no smart contract dispute resolution mechanism, and no member identification requirements. RIBPI's 6-page Legislative Analysis includes recommended amendment language.

4. PROTECTING CITIZENS' PRIVATE KEYS

H.7957 (House) / S.2196 (Senate) — Cryptographic Key Protection

House: Rep. Casey | Innovation, Internet & Technology Committee (heard 3/5/26, held for further study). **Senate:** Sens. DiPalma, Gu, Burke, Urso, Paolino, Zurier | AI & Emerging Technology Committee (heard 4/7/26, held for further study).

Prohibits courts and government agencies from compelling production of a private cryptographic key when the corresponding public key can provide the necessary information. The bill preserves every existing tool available to courts; it simply establishes that the private key itself should not be demanded when less invasive means suffice.

RIBPI Position: Strong Support

Mirrors Wyoming's 2023 HB0086 (Senate 31–0, House 41–13). A private key is not an asset — it is a master credential to every asset, identity, and right secured by that key. Compelling disclosure is analogous to demanding a deed when a court only needs a mailing address. RIBPI's 13-page Fiscal Impact Analysis projects one-time implementation cost of \$15,000–\$35,000 and zero ongoing fiscal exposure.

5. REDUCING FRICTION FOR DIGITAL ASSET PAYMENTS

S.2021 — Bitcoin Tax De Minimis Exemption

Introduced January 9, 2026 by Sen. Peter A. Appollonio. **Senate Finance Committee. Hearing scheduled Monday, June 8, 2026.**

Creates a de minimis exemption from state income and capital gains tax for small-scale Bitcoin transactions. Bitcoin sales or exchanges up to \$5,000/month and \$20,000/year would be exempt. Taxpayers self-certify on their annual return and maintain reasonable records. One-year pilot with a built-in sunset (effective January 1, 2027; sunsets January 1, 2028).

RIBPI Position: Strong Support

RIBPI drafted the 2025 predecessor (S.0451) and worked with Sen. Appollonio to refine S.2021. Under current law, every Bitcoin transaction triggers a capital gains calculation. The fiscal impact

is estimated at \$500K–\$2.5M annually (0.01–0.04% of general revenue). RIBPI's 15-page Fiscal Impact Analysis includes three-scenario revenue modeling and comparative state analysis.

6. VIRTUAL CURRENCY KIOSK REGULATION

H.5121 Sub A / S.0016 Sub A — Virtual Currency Kiosk Regulation (Enacted)

Signed into law June 2025. Codified as Chapter 19-14.3 of the General Laws / P.L. 2025, ch. 113.

The foundational kiosk law. Created Rhode Island's licensing and regulatory framework for virtual currency kiosk operators: daily transaction limits (\$2,000 new / \$5,000 existing customers), mandatory on-screen fraud disclosures, full-time compliance officer requirement, blockchain analytics mandates, refund obligations for scam victims, live customer service requirements, and quarterly reporting to DBR.

RIBPI Position: Concerns

The bill addresses a real problem — crypto kiosk scams targeting elderly Rhode Islanders. RIBPI has identified structural flaws: passive disclosure walls in place of active intervention; one-size-fits-all compliance burden with no risk tiering; statutory caps fixed below the Bank Secrecy Act's \$10,000 Currency Transaction Report threshold; no criminal enforcement tools targeting actual scammers. RIBPI's current position is that further kiosk legislation should be held pending the Blockchain Study Commission.

H.7955 (House) / S.2648 (Senate) — Expanding Kiosk Definitions

Introduced February 27, 2026. **House:** Reps. Casimiro, Donovan, Spears, Potter, Alzate, Shallcross Smith | Innovation, Internet & Technology Committee (heard 3/5/26, held for further study). **Senate:** Sens. Gu, Britto, Bell, Tikoian, Kallman | Senate Commerce Committee (heard 4/14/26, held for further study).

Amends § 19-14.3-1.1 to capture businesses using digital products or applications directing customers to pay in person — including through a clerk or other intermediary — rather than through a physical kiosk. Targets app-to-counter and voucher-at-register models that avoid the existing framework.

RIBPI Position: Concerns — Supports the goal, opposes the drafting

RIBPI supports closing the loophole but has identified five drafting problems: (1) "facilitates or enables" language is overbroad; (2) every newly captured entity inherits the full Chapter 19-14.3 compliance burden (low-to-mid six figures annually) with no tiering; (3) critical terms are undefined; (4) no implementation period; and (5) the custodial / non-custodial distinction is

collapsed. **RIBPI's ask to Senate Commerce: hold S.2648 until the Blockchain Study Commission has been enacted.**

7. THE BIG PICTURE

These eight bills represent the most significant blockchain and digital asset legislative activity in Rhode Island's history. Taken together, they address the full lifecycle of digital asset policy: how the state studies and understands the technology (study commission), how it creates an innovation-friendly environment (blockchain growth act), how decentralized organizations form and operate with legal clarity (DAO LLC act), how digital property rights are protected (private key legislation), how everyday transactions are treated for tax purposes (de minimis exemption), and how consumers are protected at point of sale (kiosk regulation).

RIBPI's overarching concern is that Rhode Island has been legislating in these areas without a coordinated strategy. Kiosk bills move through Innovation, the tax bill through Senate Finance, the blockchain growth act and DAO LLC act through House Corporations — all without a dedicated subcommittee or commission to coordinate these efforts. **This is precisely why S.2198 Sub A matters.** Its passage on the Senate floor June 10 would create the institutional infrastructure to evaluate these issues holistically rather than piecemeal.

Rhode Island ranks 40th on the Tax Foundation 2026 State Tax Competitiveness Index and 46th on CNBC's 2025 America's Top States for Business (tied with Louisiana). The state competes directly with New Hampshire, which has no state income tax and has already enacted the first state Bitcoin reserve law (HB 302). We cannot match that. But we can be smarter — and these bills, properly crafted and coordinated, are an opportunity to position Rhode Island as a thoughtful, innovation-friendly state in the digital economy.

8. QUICK REFERENCE

Bill	Subject	Status	RIBPI
H.7956 / S.2198 Sub A	Blockchain Study Commission	Senate Floor Vote Jun 10 ; House held Mar 5	Strong Support
H.7413	Blockchain Growth Act / SPDI / Sandbox	Held for further study Feb 3	Support
H.7843	DAO LLC Act	Held for further study Apr 2	Support with Amendments
H.7957 / S.2196	Private Key Protection	Held Mar 5 / Apr 7	Strong Support
S.2021	Bitcoin De Minimis	Senate Finance	Strong Support

	Tax Exemption	hearing Jun 8	
H.5121A / S.0016A	Kiosk Regulation (enacted)	Law since June 2025	Concerns
H.7955 / S.2648	Kiosk Definition Expansion	Held Mar 5 / Apr 14	Concerns

Prepared by the Rhode Island Bitcoin Policy Initiative. Contact: Dan Hersey, Founder. dan@ribpi.com. @RIBTCPolicy. This overview is intended for informational and policy discussion purposes. It does not constitute legal advice.

APPENDIX: SOURCES AND REFERENCES

Bill Status (verified June 6, 2026)

- status.rilegislature.gov, full 2026 session bill status reports
- Senate AI & Emerging Technology Committee minutes (June 2, 2026, S.2198 Sub A do-pass recommendation)
- Senate Calendar for June 10, 2026
- All committee hearing records for 2026 bills tracked above

RIBPI Companion Publications (available at ribpi.com/research)

- H.7413 Fiscal Impact Analysis (16 pages)
- H.7956 / S.2198 Fiscal Impact Analysis (15 pages)
- H.7957 / S.2196 Fiscal Impact Analysis (13 pages)
- H.7843 Legislative Analysis (6 pages)
- H.7955 / S.2648 Policy Brief (5 pages)
- S.2021 Executive Summary, plus the supporting Bitcoin Microtransaction Exemption white paper

Federal Context

- GENIUS Act, P.L. 119-27, signed July 18, 2025
- Digital Asset Market Clarity Act, H.R. 3633 (119th Congress), passed House July 17, 2025
- Executive Order 14233 (March 6, 2025), Strategic Bitcoin Reserve
- Executive Order 14178 (January 23, 2025), retail CBDC prohibition

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End of Report